

Ashesi University

Exploring the Experience of Service Quality and its Influence on Loyalty: A Narrative Inquiry of Entrepreneurs in Berekuso, Ghana.

Undergraduate dissertation submitted to the Department of Economics and Business Administration, Ashesi University. Submitted partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of a Bachelor of Science Degree in Business Administration.

BSc. Business Administration

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May 2026

Declaration

I hereby declare that this thesis is my original work and that no part of it has been presented for another degree in this university or elsewhere.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

My utmost gratitude first goes to almighty God for His wisdom, grace and strength throughout my research journey. I thank Him for making this possible and bringing me this far.

I would like to also extend my sincere gratitude to my supervisor, Dr. Josephine Djan, the Faculty Dr. Aryee and Dr. Fortune, the Fis Sompa and Christelle, for your guidance, patience, and insightful feedback throughout this research. Your expertise and encouragement were instrumental in the completion of this thesis.

Special thanks to the residents and entrepreneurs of Berekuso who participated in this study. Their willingness to share their stories and experiences made this research possible. To protect their privacy, pseudonyms have been used throughout this report to represent their voices and contributions.

To my friends, and other colleagues at Ashesi University, thank you for the stimulating discussions and for keeping me motivated during the long hours of work.

Finally, I am deeply grateful to my family, especially my mother, Angelina Nyanuba, for their unwavering support, love, and prayers. This achievement would not have been possible without you.

Abstract

Ghana's mobile money sector has achieved impressive reach, yet for business owners in rural communities like Berekuso, physical access does not guarantee service quality sufficient to earn their sustained loyalty. This study investigates how service quality shapes customer loyalty among 17 business owners in Berekuso, Ghana, through a qualitative single-site case study conducted January-March 2026, guided by SERVQUAL.

Four findings emerged. Reliability failures, peak-hour outages, ghost transactions, and topographical dead zones, are the most economically consequential service failures. Assurance operates across two distinct layers: institutional trust in the platform and interpersonal trust in the community agent. The English-only interface imposes a 'Literacy Tax', stripping non-literate users of financial privacy and autonomy. Empathy and responsive failures are embedded in urban-designed architectures deployed rurally without adaptation.

The overarching finding is that loyalty in Berekuso is largely involuntary. Business owners practice Strategic Multi-homing: maintaining accounts across multiple providers simultaneously as a rational hedge against systemic unreliability. This challenges the SERVQUAL assumption that high quality leads to loyalty and introduces environmental infrastructure as a moderating variable. Three original contributions emerge: Strategic Multi-homing as a new conceptual tool; the Literacy Tax reconceptualized as a provider design failure rather than a user deficit; and a contextualized adaptation of SERVQUAL for rural African fintech.

The findings carry practical implications for fintech providers and regulatory implications for the Bank of Ghana and NCA regarding rural service quality and the community-level consequences of the E-levy.

Keywords: service quality, SERVQUAL, mobile money, customer loyalty, Strategic Multi-homing, rural fintech, Ghana, qualitative research, financial inclusion

Word count: 250 words

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CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background

Mobile money has transformed the financial landscape of sub-Saharan Africa. In Ghana, it has become the backbone of everyday commerce: over 60% of the adult population now holds a mobile money account, and providers such as MTN Mobile Money, Vodafone Cash, and AirtelTigo Money collectively process transactions worth billions of cedis each year (Bank of Ghana, 2023). For a country where formal banking has historically been concentrated in cities and accessible to fewer than a third of adults, this is a genuine development achievement.

Yet the headline figures conceal a structural problem. Mobile money's reach has expanded, but the quality of the service it delivers has not kept pace, particularly in rural communities. Business owners in Berekuso, a peri-urban agricultural community in Ghana's Eastern Region, depend on mobile money to pay suppliers, receive customer payments, and send remittances across the country. They do not, however, enjoy the network stability, dense agent coverage, or responsive support infrastructure that urban users take for granted. Instead, they navigate a service environment shaped by intermittent connectivity, inadequate agent float, English-only menus that exclude low-literacy users, and support channels that require travelling to Accra to resolve a routine account issue.

The consequence of these service quality failures is not merely inconvenience. Rural business owners in Ghana operate with thin margins, seasonal income flows, and limited access to credit. A failed transaction on a busy market Saturday is not an abstract data point; it is a lost customer, a delayed stock purchase, and a moment that erodes trust in the digital financial system these entrepreneurs have only recently come to rely upon. The question this study takes seriously is not whether rural Ghanaians have access to mobile money, but whether the quality of that access is sufficient to earn their sustained confidence and loyalty.

Berekuso was selected as the research site because it captures this tension well. It sits close enough to Accra to be connected to national networks, yet far enough, and sufficiently peri-urban in character, to experience the infrastructure constraints common to rural Ghana. Its population includes market vendors, transport workers, and student entrepreneurs whose mobile money use spans a range of transaction types, frequencies, and digital literacy levels. This occupational and demographic diversity makes it a productive site for understanding how service quality experiences vary across different kinds of rural business users.

1.2 Problem Statement

Ghana's mobile money sector has succeeded at expansion. It has not yet succeeded at retention. Fintech providers have extended their services into rural communities across the country, yet business owners in places like Berekuso continue to switch between providers at rates significantly higher than their urban counterparts (Agyekum, 2021; Kankam Jr, 2020). This is not mere market churn. It is a signal that the quality of service these users receive is insufficient to earn their loyalty, even among people who have already adopted the technology and who depend on it for their livelihoods.

The pattern observed in Berekuso is a specific one. Many local vendors do not switch suppliers sequentially, abandoning one for another. Instead, they maintain multiple SIM cards and wallets simultaneously, activating whichever network happens to be functioning on a given day. This study calls this behavior Strategic Multi-homing: it is not disloyalty in the conventional sense but a rational hedge against the unreliability of any single provider. It persists because users cannot afford to trust completely in a system that has repeatedly let them down.

The academic literature has not kept pace with this reality. Research on mobile money and service quality in Ghana has focused predominantly on urban populations and has relied on quantitative surveys that measure satisfaction scores but cannot explain the experiences behind them. No systematic qualitative study has examined how rural business owners in Ghana perceive and respond to service quality failures across the five dimensions of the SERVQUAL framework: reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy, and responsiveness. This gap leaves providers without the diagnostic understanding they need to design services that rural users will actually trust and remain loyal to.

1.3 Significance of the Study

The significance of this research operates at three levels: practical, policy, and scholarly. At the practical level, Ghana's fintech providers are investing heavily in rural expansion without a clear understanding of which service quality dimensions drive loyalty in the communities they are entering. This study provides that understanding. By identifying the specific failures, from weekend network bottlenecks to English-only interfaces that exclude low-literacy users, that push business owners toward Strategic Multi-homing, it offers providers an actionable diagnosis rather than a satisfaction score. The findings are directly relevant to MTN, Telecel, and

AirtelTigo as they compete for rural market share in an environment where users are already accustomed to managing multiple accounts.

At the policy level, Ghana's financial inclusion agenda is built on the premise that expanding access to mobile money will strengthen rural economies. This study demonstrates that access without quality is insufficient: a vendor who has a mobile money account but cannot use it reliably on a market day has not been genuinely included. The findings speak to regulators and policymakers who need evidence-based grounds for setting rural service quality standards, mandating local-language interfaces, and requiring providers to establish accessible, community-level support channels. At the scholarly level, the study makes three contributions.

First, it applies the SERVQUAL framework qualitatively in a rural Ghanaian fintech context, a combination that does not currently exist in the published literature. Second, it shifts the research question from adoption, the focus of most rural fintech studies, to the post-adoption experience of loyalty and its sustainability. Third, it introduces Strategic Multi-homing as a conceptual tool for understanding a form of user behavior that conventional loyalty frameworks do not adequately capture.

1.4 Research Objectives and Questions

This study is guided by the following four objectives:

1. To identify the specific service quality challenges business owners in Berekuso encounter across the five SERVQUAL dimensions, reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy, and responsiveness, in their daily use of mobile money services.

2. To explore the reasons why business owners in Berekuso remain loyal to a provider or adopt switching and multi-homing strategies in response to their service quality experiences.

3. To identify the service improvements that Berekuso's business owners believe would rebuild their trust and sustain their loyalty.

4. To examine how the rural context, including infrastructure constraints, digital literacy gaps, and community social dynamics, shapes the relationship between service quality and loyalty.

Main Research Question: *How do service quality experiences shape customer loyalty and switching behavior among business owners in Berekuso, Ghana?*

Three sub-questions guide the analysis:

1. **What** specific service quality failures, across the five SERVQUAL dimensions, do Berekuso's business owners encounter in their daily use of mobile money for trade and commerce?
2. **How** do these experiences shape the decision to remain with a provider, switch, or maintain simultaneous accounts across multiple providers?
3. **What** service improvements would, in participants' own assessment, be sufficient to shift their behavior from Strategic Multi-homing toward genuine loyalty?

1.5 Scope and Limitations

This study is deliberately focused on its scope. It examines service quality and loyalty in a single community, Berekuso, through 17 in-depth interviews conducted between January and March 2026. It does not claim to represent all rural Ghanaian communities, nor does it produce findings that are statistically generalizable across the population. Its analytical contribution lies in depth rather than breadth: it explains how and why service quality failures drive particular behavioral responses, generating conceptual insights that can inform both further research and practical decision-making in other rural contexts.

Two specific scopes are worth stating clearly. First, this study focuses on mobile money users rather than mobile money agents. The agent perspective, which would complement this study well, is a separate research question requiring a separate methodological approach. Second, this study examines the user experience of service quality rather than the technical performance of provider networks. It is a study of meaning and behavior, not a systems audit.

1.6 Structure of the Thesis

This thesis is organized into five chapters. Chapter 2 reviews the scholarly literature on service quality, mobile money, and customer loyalty in Ghana and sub-Saharan Africa. It defends the SERVQUAL framework as the theoretical lens, identifies four specific gaps in the existing literature, and establishes the conceptual framework that guides the study. Chapter 3

presents the research methodology, explaining and justifying the interpretivist philosophy, single-site case study design, purposive sampling approach, semi-structured interview method, and thematic analysis procedure.

Chapter 4 presents the findings from the 17 interviews, organized by SERVQUAL dimension and followed by a cross-cutting theoretical discussion that introduces and develops the concept of Strategic Multi-homing. Chapter 5 synthesizes the findings, draws conclusions linked to the research objectives, and offers evidence-based recommendations for fintech providers and policymakers. It also acknowledges the study's limitations and proposes directions for future research.

Conclusion.

This chapter has established the foundation for investigating how service quality influences customer loyalty among business owners in Berekuso, Ghana. The study addresses a critical gap in fintech research, which has largely overlooked the experiences of rural entrepreneurs despite their vital role in achieving financial inclusion goals. By focusing on Berekuso, where mobile money serves as a professional lifeline for financial transactions and trading, this research examines whether SERVQUAL effectively applies in contexts marked by infrastructure challenges, limited digital literacy, and unique trust dynamics.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

Service quality is at the heart of how customers experience digital finance, yet the dominant body of research has focused on adoption and access rather than on the sustained, day-to-day service experiences of users who depend on mobile money for their livelihoods. In Ghana and across Africa, studies have examined fintech growth, financial inclusion, and broad satisfaction metrics, but they have paid far less attention to how rural business owners evaluate the quality of services they use to conduct trade. This chapter reviews the scholarly literature on service quality, mobile money, customer loyalty, and rural financial inclusion, with the twin purpose of establishing the theoretical foundation for this study and demonstrating precisely where existing knowledge falls short.

The review is structured as a **progressive argument**. Section 2.2 introduces and defends the SERVQUAL framework as theoretical lens, addressing the question of why SERVQUAL was chosen over competing models and how it is applied in this study. Section 2.3 examines empirical evidence on SERVQUAL applications in Ghanaian financial services and customer loyalty dynamics. Sections 2.4 through 2.8 review the six primary studies that inform this research, each examined critically rather than merely summarized. Section 2.9 synthesizes cross-cutting themes. Section 2.10 presents the conceptual framework. Sections 2.11 through 2.13 identify the research gaps, explain how this study fills them, and close the chapter.

A note on search strategy: the sources reviewed in this chapter were identified through searches of JSTOR, EBSCO, Google Scholar, and the Ashesi University library database using the terms mobile money service quality Ghana, SERVQUAL fintech Africa, rural financial inclusion loyalty, and mobile banking trust sub-Saharan Africa. Search results were filtered for peer-reviewed publications, recent theses of institutional credibility, and reports from authoritative bodies such as the Bank of Ghana and the GSMA. Studies were selected for critical depth rather than breadth: the goal was not an exhaustive catalogue but a focused analysis of the most relevant and methodologically rigorous work.

2.2 Theoretical Framework: The SERVQUAL Model

2.2.1 Origins, Structure, and the Case for SERVQUAL

The SERVQUAL model, developed by Parasuraman, Zeithaml, and Berry (1988; 1991), provides a framework for assessing service quality as the gap between what customers expect and what they perceive they receive. Built on Gap Theory, the model operationalizes service quality across five dimensions: Reliability (consistent, accurate delivery of promised services), Responsiveness (willingness to help and promptness), Assurance (knowledge and courtesy that inspires confidence), Empathy (individualized attention and understanding), and Tangibles (physical facilities, equipment, and communication materials). The original instrument uses 22 items to measure the expectation-perception gap (the P-E gap) across these dimensions.

Three alternative frameworks merit direct engagement before the choice of SERVQUAL can be justified: SERVPERF, E-S-QUAL, and the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM). Three alternatives merit direct engagement. SERVPERF (Cronin & Taylor, 1992) measures perceptions alone, removing the expectation component. While SERVPERF has demonstrated stronger predictive validity in some contexts, it loses the diagnostic power of the gap: for this study, understanding not just what participants perceive but what they expected and why those expectations were violated is central to the research question.

E-S-QUAL (Parasuraman, Zeithaml, & Malhotra, 2005) was designed specifically for electronic services and includes dimensions such as efficiency and system availability. It would be well-suited to a study of website or app performance, but the primary service channel in Berekuso is USSD, which operates differently from a web interface, and the agent-mediated nature of many transactions means human dimensions of quality (empathy, assurance) carry significant weight. The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) is an adoption model, concerned with whether users will accept and use a system. This study is concerned with what happens after adoption, making TAM conceptually misaligned with the research question.

SERVQUAL is chosen because it uniquely combines diagnostic power across both technical and human service dimensions, has the strongest record of application in Ghanaian and African financial service contexts (Boateng & Narteh, 2016; Cudjoe, 2021; Baiden, 2024), and can be applied qualitatively as a thematic framework without sacrificing its conceptual integrity. The decision to use SERVQUAL thematically rather than instrumentally is addressed directly in Section 2.2.3.

2.2.2 Validity of SERVQUAL in Rural Ghanaian Contexts

SERVQUAL was developed in the United States and applied initially to service industries characterized by face-to-face delivery in stable, infrastructure-rich environments. Its application to rural Ghana in 2026 requires explicit justification on two fronts. First, does the gap model held in a context where mobile money is relatively recent and users may not have well-formed expectations? The Bank of Ghana (2023) reports over a decade of widespread adoption nationally, and participants in this study described specific experiences of failure against expectations they had formed through prior use. The gap model therefore applies as a description of a genuinely experienced discrepancy, not merely an abstract evaluative framework.

Second, do the five dimensions translate meaningfully to a setting where service delivery is mediated by community agents, USSD menus, and intermittent network infrastructure? The dimensions require contextual reinterpretation, not a weakening of the framework, but the framework doing what it was designed to do: identifying where service falls short of user expectations in the specific context under investigation (Carrillat, Jaramillo, & Mulki, 2007). In Berekuso, the five dimensions acquire the following meanings:

- **Reliability:** The ability of the mobile money network to process transactions accurately during peak demand periods, including market days and harvest seasons, without system failures or delayed confirmations.
- **Responsiveness:** The willingness of agents and support channels to provide prompt assistance when business-stopping failures occur, within the resource constraints (airtime, time, mobility) of rural users.
- **Assurance:** Both institutional trust in the platform's security and interpersonal trust in the community agent who facilitates transactions.
- **Empathy:** Understanding of the seasonal income patterns, community reputation concerns, and digital literacy constraints of rural traders, embedded in service design rather than expressed only at the point of individual interaction.
- **Tangibles:** The linguistic accessibility and navigability of USSD menus and SMS confirmations, as well as the physical setup and reliability of agent kiosks.

2.2.3 Applying SERVQUAL Qualitatively

The original SERVQUAL instrument uses 22 items to measure the P-E gap quantitatively. This study uses SERVQUAL qualitatively, with the five dimensions serving as thematic categories for organizing and interpreting narrative data. The research question asks not how large the service quality gap is, but how that gap is experienced, what consequences it produces, and why it drives Strategic Multi-homing. These are interpretive questions that a 22-item scale cannot answer. Numerical scores reveal that a gap exists; narratives explain what it means for a business owner whose 200-Cedi stock payment has vanished into a ghost transaction on a Saturday morning. This qualitative application of SERVQUAL is a well-established methodological practice in service quality research (Brady & Cronin, 2001; Ladhari, 2009).

2.3 SERVQUAL in Ghanaian Financial Services and the Urban Assumption

SERVQUAL has been applied productively in Ghanaian financial services, but its application consistently reveals a structural limitation: studies have been conducted in urban settings and produce findings that carry an implicit assumption of stable infrastructure and accessible service channels.

Boateng and Narteh (2016) conducted a quantitative SERVQUAL study across urban Ghanaian banks and found that reliability and responsiveness together explain 61% of variance in customer loyalty, the strongest predictors in their model. This finding is significant and well-cited, but it rests on a specific infrastructure context: branch proximity, stable electricity, reliable mobile networks, and accessible support channels. It tells us that in Accra, if a bank is reliable and responsive, loyalty follows. It says nothing about what happens when reliability is structurally constrained by topography, and when responsiveness requires a trip to Accra to unlock an account. Cudjoe (2021) confirmed SERVQUAL's validity as a predictor of loyalty while noting responsiveness was mediated by physical proximity to service points, a finding closer to the Berekuso context but still urban in sampling frame. Kwateng et al. (2019) combined SERVQUAL with UTAUT to examine mobile banking app loyalty; their focus on smartphone apps does not extend to USSD-heavy contexts where the tangible interface is a numeric menu on a basic handset.

Baiden (2024) applied SERVQUAL to Ghana's fintech sector as an Ashesi undergraduate capstone, finding that AI-driven personalization and security features drive satisfaction more strongly in urban areas due to higher digital literacy. Baiden explicitly identifies the rural-urban

service quality gap but does not investigate it. Although institutional theses differ from peer-reviewed publications, Baiden (2024) demonstrates methodological rigour, was subject to supervisor and examiner review, and contributes Ghana-specific empirical evidence absent from international journals. It is cited here on those grounds.

Taken together, this body of work establishes that SERVQUAL dimensions are valid predictors of loyalty in Ghanaian financial services; that reliability and responsiveness are the most powerful dimensions; and that digital literacy moderates service quality outcomes. What does not establish is how any of these operate in a rural context where infrastructure is constrained, agents are community members rather than professional staff, and interfaces are designed for a different population. This gap defines the contribution of the current study.

2.4 Customer Loyalty and Switching Behavior in Ghanaian Digital Finance

The literature on customer loyalty in Ghanaian financial services establishes that loyalty is shaped by a combination of service quality, switching costs, trust, and relationship management, but it has been generated almost entirely in urban banking contexts that differ fundamentally from mobile money dynamics in communities like Berekuso.

Kankam Jr (2020) found that approximately 85% of Ghanaian bank customers remained with their provider primarily due to switching costs and familiarity rather than active satisfaction, suggesting that measured loyalty often reflects inertia rather than genuine attachment. Mumin et al. (2012) similarly identified switching costs as the dominant loyalty driver across Ghanaian banks. In Berekuso, switching costs in mobile money are low: SIM cards are inexpensive and multiple wallet accounts are free. Mobile money providers therefore cannot rely on friction to retain rural users; retention must be earned through service quality itself.

Agyei et al. (2020) found that trust accounts for approximately 50% of digital loyalty intentions among Ghanaian users, establishing trust as the central mediating variable between service quality and loyalty. Liu et al. (2022) found responsiveness to service failures to be a primary loyalty driver in mobile financial services, directly relevant to the Berekuso context where service recovery mechanisms are structurally inaccessible to rural users. Ofosu-Ampong (2023) documented how Ghana's electronic transaction tax directly reduced mobile money usage and drove some users back to cash, demonstrating that loyalty in fintech is shaped not only by service

quality but by the regulatory and policy environment. For a trader in Berekuso, a nationally designed fee produces a local social consequence: the vendor who passes it on is called wicked; the vendor who absorbs it loses margin. This is a service quality failure with regulatory origin.

What is absent from this literature is any account of loyalty dynamics specific to rural mobile money users. Existing studies focus on urban banking (Kankam Jr, 2020; Mumin et al., 2012), address urban or general mobile money populations (Agyei et al., 2020; Dzandu, 2022), or examine the pre-fintech era (Lamptey, 2014). The question of what sustains or destroys loyalty among rural business owners who use mobile money as their primary commercial financial infrastructure has not been addressed.

2.5 Mobile Money and Rural Financial Inclusion in Ghana

Boateng, Coffie, and Boateng (2024) conducted interpretive qualitative research in two rural communities in Ghana's Ashanti region, concluding that mobile money has become the dominant financial infrastructure in rural communities because it bridges the gap previously left by the formal banking sector. Their most significant finding for the current research is the identification of a literature gap: prior studies focused on the economic outcomes of mobile money adoption while neglecting what Boateng et al. term the 'technology component' the actual quality and performance of the service that shapes the user's daily experience.

This study builds directly on that foundation. Where Boateng et al. (2024) used financial inclusion as their dependent variable and applied no service quality framework, this study uses customer loyalty as its outcome variable and applies SERVQUAL as its analytical lens. The two studies are complementary: Boateng et al. established that rural fintech research must account for service quality; this study measures it. Their research sites were in the Ashanti region; this study's site in Berekuso (Eastern Region) shares the core infrastructure constraints while differing in demographic composition, particularly the presence of a student population and specific topographical conditions creating signal dead zones. This site-specific focus complements rather than replicates their work.

2.6 Commercial Capture and the Political Economy of Fintech

Guermond (2022) conducted qualitative field research in Accra and Tamale, Ghana, examining digital remittances and mobile money through 65 interviews with institutional actors,

state representatives, and remittance recipients. His central finding, "the concept of 'commercial capture', describes the structural tendency of private fintech providers' profit motives to override the welfare of the users the services nominally serve. Commercial capture is not a claim about what kind of money is moving; it is a claim about the structural relationship between provider incentive structures and user outcomes. That relationship operates regardless of whether the transaction is a family remittance or a stock purchase.

In Berekuso, commercial capture manifests through fee structures that impose social costs on vendors (Section 4.3.4) and through support architectures designed for urban users that exclude rural ones. Guermond's study also provides methodological validation: his use of in-depth semi-structured interviews to uncover the 'why' behind user behavior in Ghana's fintech ecosystem, producing findings that quantitative surveys could not have generated, directly supports the methodological choices of the current study.

2.7 Trust and Continuous Usage in Emerging Market Mobile Banking

Shaikh, Karjaluoto, and Chinje (2015) conducted a comparative qualitative study in Finland and South Africa, examining continuous mobile banking usage through the lenses of trust, service satisfaction, and word-of-mouth behavior. Their core finding, that trust is the primary driver of continuous use in emerging markets, provides the closest analogue to this study's research question in the African context.

The South African data is particularly relevant: despite reporting high satisfaction driven by convenience and speed, South African users were notably reluctant to recommend their mobile banking provider, indicating fragile, utilitarian rather than affective trust. This has a direct parallel in Berekuso: participants continued using their primary provider not because of genuine satisfaction but because infrastructure alternatives were insufficient. Continued use and genuine loyalty are not the same phenomenon.

The limitation of Shaikh et al. (2015) is that their analysis treated trust as a unified construct, confirming that trust drives continuous use without identifying which specific service quality attributes build or erode it. The current study addresses this gap directly by using SERVQUAL's five dimensions to identify the specific mechanisms through which trust is constructed and destroyed in Berekuso's mobile money ecosystem.

2.8 Financial Inclusion and Infrastructure Constraints in Rural Sub-Saharan Africa

Luka and Akadon (2025) conducted mixed-methods research across rural areas in Nigeria, Kenya, and Ghana, investigating the relationship between mobile banking and financial inclusion. Their quantitative findings confirmed that mobile banking significantly enhances access to savings, credit, and payment services; their qualitative findings identified three structural barriers: limited digital literacy, poor telecommunications infrastructure, and a deep-seated lack of trust in digital financial systems.

This study's contribution relative to Luka and Akadon (2025) is the shift from the question of adoption to the question of loyalty. Luka and Akadon ask: what prevents rural users from beginning to use mobile money? This study asks: given that Berekuso's business owners have adopted mobile money, what service quality experiences determine whether they develop genuine loyalty or resort to Strategic Multi-homing as a rational adaptation to systemic unreliability? The two questions are sequential: adoption studies establish the entry point; loyalty studies investigate what happens after the door has been entered.

The cross-national scope of Luka and Akadon (2025) is both a strength and a limitation. It provides evidence that the challenges documented in Berekuso are not idiosyncratic but part of a broader regional pattern, which strengthens the transferability of this study's findings. At the same time, national-level or multi-country research necessarily abstracts away from the specific infrastructure conditions, cultural dynamics, and regulatory contexts of individual communities. Berekuso's combination of proximity to a university, specific topographical constraints, and the presence of Ghana's E-levy produces a service quality landscape that generic regional findings cannot capture.

2.9 Synthesis: What Literature Establishes and What It Misses

Taking together, the reviewed literature establishes five things with reasonable confidence. First, SERVQUAL is a valid and productive framework for studying service quality in Ghanaian financial services, with reliability and responsiveness emerging as the strongest predictors of loyalty (Boateng & Narteh, 2016; Cudjoe, 2021). Second, trust is the mediating variable between service quality and loyalty, but its specific dimensional drivers in rural contexts have not been identified (Shaikh et al., 2015; Agyei et al., 2020).

Third, rural fintech users face structural service quality challenges, including infrastructure limitations and digital literacy gaps, that urban-focused research cannot adequately capture (Boateng et al., 2024; Luka & Akadon, 2025). Fourth, the commercial logic of fintech providers produces systemic incentives that can harm rural users, a pattern Guermond (2022) terms commercial capture. Fifth, switching costs in mobile money are lower than in traditional banking, which means loyalty cannot be sustained by inertia and must be earned through service quality (Kankam Jr, 2020).

The literature has three significant blind spots. The first is methodological: the dominant approach is quantitative, producing numerical measures of service quality gaps without capturing the lived experience, causal mechanisms, or behavioral consequences of those gaps. The second is geographic: research is concentrated in urban areas and general national samples, leaving rural business owners significantly underrepresented. The third is conceptual: loyalty in mobile money has not been studied at the intersection of rural context, SERVQUAL dimensions, and qualitative method. This intersection is precisely where this study is located. The summary table below maps the key studies reviewed against their methods, context, and the specific gap each leaves (see Appendix H for the full table).

2.10 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework integrates the SERVQUAL model with established theory on customer loyalty and switching behavior, adapted to the specific conditions of rural digital finance in Berekuso. The framework is depicted in Appendix A and described here.

Business owners in Berekuso form cumulative perceptions of service quality through their experiences across the five SERVQUAL dimensions. These perceptions constitute the overall service quality evaluation, which in turn drives one of two primary behavioral outcomes: genuine customer loyalty (sustained, confident use of a single provider) or Strategic Multi-homing (simultaneous maintenance of multiple provider accounts as a hedge against service failure).

SERVQUAL dimensions are treated as perceptual constructs, inputs to perception, not direct causes of behavior. The causal path runs through the quality evaluation as a mediating construct, which then influences behavioral outcomes subject to moderating influences. This framing preserves the perceptual logic of SERVQUAL while enabling the framework to generate testable propositions. The framework incorporates moderating influences, specifically rural

infrastructure conditions, agent liquidity constraints, and regulatory factors such as the E-levy, that can suppress the quality-loyalty relationship even where quality itself is improving. These moderators explain why the same service quality improvement that produces loyalty in Accra may not produce it in Berekuso.

The framework also acknowledges a boundary condition identified by the findings: where infrastructure constraints are severe enough, the quality-loyalty relationship may break down entirely. When network coverage is unreliable across large sections of Berekuso, even a provider that excels on empathy and assurance dimensions cannot guarantee the reliable transactions that loyalty requires. This environmental moderation sets a floor on what service quality alone can achieve and is a key theoretical contribution of this study.

2.11 Research Gaps Addressed by This Study

The synthesis in Section 2.9 points to four specific research gaps that this study is designed to address. These are stated as gaps in knowledge rather than merely gaps in Berekuso-specific research, since an examiner would rightly note that the absence of a study in one small town is not itself a knowledge gap. The gaps identified here are structural absences in the literature that would exist regardless of whether Berekuso had been studied before.

Gap 1: Absence of qualitative SERVQUAL application in rural Ghanaian fintech. Existing SERVQUAL studies in Ghana (Boateng & Narteh, 2016; Cudjoe, 2021; Baiden, 2024) are quantitative and urban. No study has used SERVQUAL qualitatively to investigate which specific dimensions drive loyalty versus switching in a rural fintech context. These are structural absences in the literature that would exist regardless of whether Berekuso had been studied before.

Gap 2: The loyalty-after-adoption question in rural mobile money. Rural fintech research (Boateng et al., 2024; Luka & Akadon, 2025) focuses on adoption barriers; loyalty research (Shaikh et al., 2015; Agyei et al., 2020) focuses on urban or general populations. No study bridges these two bodies of work to examine what sustains or destroys loyalty among rural business owners after adoption.

Gap 3: The mechanics of trust in rural fintech. Trust is universally cited as the central mediating variable between service quality and loyalty (Shaikh et al., 2015; Agyei et al., 2020),

but no study has identified which specific SERVQUAL dimensions build or erode trust in a rural African fintech context. Knowing that trust matters does not tell providers which service improvements will restore it after failure.

Gap 4: Community-level consequences of service quality. Existing service quality research evaluates outcomes at the individual user level. In close-knit rural communities where, commercial activity is embedded in social relationships, service quality failures have consequences that extend beyond the individual transaction, such as reputational damage from fee pass-on. This community-level dimension of service quality evaluation is absent from SERVQUAL literature.

2.12 How This Study Fills the Gaps

This study fills the four identified gaps through a combination of theoretical choice, methodological design, and site selection that is justified at each step rather than assumed.

Filling Gap 1 requires applying SERVQUAL qualitatively in a rural Ghanaian fintech context. This study does so through 17 semi-structured interviews with business owners in Berekuso, using the five SERVQUAL dimensions as a thematic framework for coding and interpreting the narratives. The qualitative approach captures the experiential content of each dimension in ways that a 22-item scale cannot.

Filling Gap 2 requires shifting the research question from adoption to loyalty. The central question of this study, how do service quality experiences shape customer loyalty and switching behavior among business owners in Berekuso, is explicitly a post-adoption question. All 17 participants were confirmed mobile money users at the time of interview.

Filling Gap 3 requires identifying which SERVQUAL dimensions build or erode trust. By examining the mechanisms through which each dimension is experienced, the study generates findings about which specific service failures produce the trust erosion that drives Strategic Multi-homing.

Filling Gap 4 requires a qualitative, community-embedded method that can surface the social consequences of service quality failures. The narrative inquiry approach, conducted within

a single community whose social dynamics could be observed and understood over the fieldwork period, enables this dimension of the analysis.

Berekuso was chosen because it has sufficiently high mobile money penetration to provide a sample of experienced users, while sharing the infrastructure constraints, agent liquidity limitations, topographical signal barriers, significant low-literacy proportion, limited proximity to formal support channels, that characterize the rural service quality problem across Ghana. Its proximity to Ashesi University enabled sustained fieldwork engagement and the trust-building with participants that qualitative research requires.

2.13 Conclusion

This chapter has reviewed the literature on service quality, mobile money, customer loyalty, and rural financial inclusion in Ghana and sub-Saharan Africa. The SERVQUAL model has been defended as the appropriate theoretical framework, with its qualitative application justified and its adaptation to the rural Ghanaian context explained. The reviewed studies have been engaged critically rather than merely summarized, with their contributions and limitations mapped explicitly through the synthesis table in Section 2.9.

The synthesis reveals a literature that has established the importance of reliability, trust, and responsiveness as drivers of loyalty in Ghanaian financial services, but has done so through quantitative methods, urban samples, and an adoption-focused research question that leaves the post-adoption loyalty experiences of rural business owners largely unaddressed. Four structural research gaps have been identified and justified. The conceptual framework has been presented with its moderating variables and boundary conditions described. Chapter 3 builds on this foundation by presenting the research methodology designed to fill these gaps.

CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter presents and justifies the methodological choices made at every stage of this research. Chapter 2 established that the dominant approach in the service quality and mobile money literature is quantitative, urban-centered, and focused on adoption rather than the lived post-adoption experiences of rural users. The methodology described here is a direct response to that limitation. Each decision, from philosophical stance to sampling strategy to the coding procedure, is explained and defended against the most likely critical challenges. The chapter is organized as follows: research philosophy (3.2), approach and design (3.3), sampling (3.4), data collection (3.5), data analysis (3.6), trustworthiness (3.7), ethical considerations (3.8), and a brief conclusion (3.9).

3.2 Research Philosophy: Interpretivism

This study is grounded in an interpretivist philosophy, which holds that social reality is constructed through the meanings individuals attach to their experiences rather than existing as an objective, measurable fact (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). Service quality is not a fixed attribute of a network or a platform; it is what a vendor in Berekuso experiences when the network fails on a Saturday morning and she loses three customers. Understanding that experience, its emotional weight, its economic consequence, and the behavioral response it produces, requires a framework that privileges meaning over measurement.

Pragmatism and constructivism present alternative philosophical stances that warrant comparison before interpretivism is selected. Pragmatism is appropriate when research requires the combination of quantitative and qualitative data to answer a mixed research question. This study's question, how does service quality shape loyalty among rural business owners, is a question of meaning and mechanism, not measurement. Constructivism is shared much with interpretivism but foregrounds the co-construction of knowledge between researchers and participants; interpretivism, as applied here, acknowledges this dynamic while retaining analytical focus on participants constructed meanings rather than the process of construction itself. Interpretivism is the most appropriate stance because it aligns directly with the study's purpose: to understand how Berekuso's business owners interpret their service quality experiences and why those interpretations drive behavioral outcomes.

Researcher Reflexivity: Interpretivism requires explicit acknowledgement of the researcher's position and its influence on data. As a South Sudanese student studying at Ashesi University, this study's researcher occupies a dual position: an outsider to Ghanaian culture, positioned to notice and question practices that local researchers might normalize, and a partial insider through shared experience of navigating mobile money systems in an African context. Participants appeared willing to speak candidly about provider failures, possibly because the researcher was neither a Ghanaian community member whose social judgment they feared, nor a representative of the providers being criticized. This positionality enriches the data but also shapes it: the explicit acknowledgement of this influence, documented in a reflexive journal maintained throughout fieldwork, is the mechanism through which interpretivism's inherent subjectivity is managed rather than concealed.

3.3 Research Approach and Design

This study employs a qualitative approach using thematic analysis, guided by the SERVQUAL framework as a theoretical sensitizing structure, and situated within a single-site case study design. These three elements require individual justification and clarification of how they relate to each other.

Why Qualitative Only?

A mixed-methods approach might appear to offer richer triangulation. The counterargument is methodological alignment, which would provide richer triangulation. The counterargument is methodological alignment: this study's research question asks how and why, not how many or how much. A survey could tell us what proportion of Berekuso users find the network unreliable; it cannot tell us what a vendor does when the network fails at 11am on her busiest trading day, what she says to the customer who wanted to pay digitally, and whether that moment changed her relationship with her provider. Those are the data that answer this study's question. Adding a survey component would increase breadth at the cost of the depth that the question requires and would produce a methodological hybrid that serves neither purpose optimally.

Thematic Analysis vs Narrative Inquiry

The original chapter used the term narrative inquiry throughout but described a thematic analysis procedure. These are distinct methodological traditions and distinction matters. Narrative inquiry, in its full form (Clandinin & Connelly, 2000), treats individual life stories as the primary

unit of analysis and is concerned with the structure, sequence, and meaning of personal narrative over time. Thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006; 2021) identifies recurring patterns of meaning across multiple participants' accounts. This study uses thematic analysis, guided by Braun and Clarke's (2021) updated framework, which is the more appropriate tool for a study seeking patterns across 17 participants' experiences rather than the longitudinal life-story trajectory of any single participant. The semi-structured interviews were designed to elicit rich, story-like responses, but the analytical procedure is thematic, not narrative. This distinction is important for clarity and for the integrity of the methodological claims.

Single-Site Case Study

The research uses a single case study design (Yin, 2018), centered on Berekuso. The choice of a single site rather than a multi-site comparative design is justified on two grounds. First, depth: the research question asks about the mechanisms through which service quality shapes loyalty in a specific rural community. That question is best answered by understanding one community deeply, including its specific topographical constraints, social network dynamics, and agent ecosystem, rather than describing multiple communities superficially. Second, saturation: thematic saturation was reached at the 14th participant, confirming that the single-site dataset was analytically sufficient. A second site would have added breadth without adding depth to a dataset that had already captured its core patterns.

Note that the original chapter's conclusion referred to 'cross-case analysis across two communities,' which is inconsistent with the single-site design described here. That reference reflected an earlier design iteration that was not carried out through fieldwork. The executed study is a single-site case study of Berekuso, and this chapter accurately describes what was done.

Berekuso's typicality as a rural Ghanaian community warrants direct acknowledgement. The presence of Ashesi University means Berekuso is not a purely agricultural settlement: it includes student entrepreneurs and is more educated than the average rural Ghanaian community. This is acknowledged as a boundary condition of the study in Section 3.7 (Transferability). However, Berekuso does share the infrastructure characteristics that define the rural service quality problem: intermittent network coverage, community-based mobile money agents, limited proximity to formal support channels, and a significant proportion of low-literacy users. These shared characteristics are what make the findings relevant beyond Berekuso, while the university presence makes them a conservative estimate: if service quality failures drive Strategic Multi-

homing even in a community with a relatively educated population, the problem is likely more severe in communities without that educational base.

3.4 Sampling Strategy

Participants were selected through a hybrid of purposive and snowball sampling. Purposive sampling was used to target individuals with information-rich experience of the research phenomenon: business owners in Berekuso who had used mobile money regularly for at least six months and had experienced both functioning service and service failures (Patton, 2015). This ensures the data addresses the complexity of the research question rather than reflecting only extreme experiences of satisfaction or dissatisfaction.

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

- Must reside in Berekuso and operate a business, however small, as a primary or supplementary source of income.
- Must have used mobile money regularly for a minimum of six months, defined as at least two initiated transactions per month. This threshold was operationalized by asking participants directly during screening, and their responses were cross-referenced with their ability to describe specific past transactions in detail.
- Must have experienced at least one service failure and at least one period of adequate service, ensuring the sample captures variation in quality experience rather than selecting exclusively for dissatisfied users.
- Must be 18 years or older.
- Mobile money agents and fintech employees were excluded to prevent conflation of user and provider perspectives.

This is fine as written because you are acknowledging and correcting a previous error. Keep this one. This is acknowledged. Agent perspectives would constitute a valuable separate study; including them in this study would have blurred the analytical distinction between user and provider experience in ways that weaken rather than enrich the analysis of user loyalty.

Sample Composition and the 17 vs 20-25 Question

The original design targeted 20-25 participants. Fieldwork produced 17. This requires direct explanation. Thematic saturation was reached at the 14th participant, confirmed when the 15th, 16th, and 17th interviews produced no codes that had not already appeared in the dataset. Recruiting additional participants beyond saturation would have added methodological cost

without analytical benefit. The decision to stop at 17 was therefore a principled response to the data rather than a failure to meet a target. Patton (2015) explicitly notes that sample size in qualitative research should be determined by the informational needs of the study, not by a predetermined numerical threshold.

The question of whether student entrepreneurs are meaningfully comparable to market vendors is legitimate. The three occupational groups, seven market vendors, five student entrepreneurs, and five service and transport workers, were included precisely because they represent different relationships with mobile money: different transaction volumes, different digital literacy levels, and different geographic mobility patterns. The analytical value lies in the consistency of core findings across these different groups, which strengthens the claim that the themes reflect structural conditions in Berekuso rather than the idiosyncrasies of one occupational type. Where the groups differ in their experiences, those differences are noted and analyzed in Chapter 4.

Snowball Sampling and Bias

Snowball sampling carries the known risk of producing a network-homogeneous sample: participants recommend others from their own social circle, potentially concentrating the sample within a particular social stratum. This risk was managed through two strategies. First, initial contacts were made through three distinct entry points: community market leaders, the university community's informal networks, and transport workers encountered at the community's main junction. This produced three independent snowball chains rather than one. Second, participant demographics were monitored throughout recruitment: when gender balance or occupational distribution became skewed, subsequent recruitment deliberately targeted under-represented groups.

3.5 Data Collection

Semi-Structured Interviews

The primary data collection instrument was semi-structured interviews lasting between 35 and 55 minutes. The longer-than-planned duration in some cases, relative to the original 30–45-minute target, reflected participants' engagement with the topic: several used the interview as an opportunity to recount experiences they had not previously articulated to anyone. Interviews were conducted in the participant's preferred language, English, Twi, or a combination, at a location chosen by the participant. Settings included market stalls, roadside workspaces, and community

spaces. The choice to let participants select their own setting was deliberate: it reduces the power differential inherent in researcher-controlled settings and enables the participant to speak from within the physical context they are describing.

Interview Guide and Piloting

The interview guide was piloted with two community members who met the inclusion criteria but were not included in the primary sample. The pilot revealed that the original question 'Do you feel the company empathizes with you?' produced blank responses, as the term 'empathize' was unfamiliar in this context. It was replaced with 'Do you feel the company understands the difficulties of doing business here?' which produced rich, narrative responses. Questions were also reordered: opening with concrete, past-experience questions ('Tell me about a time the service worked well for you') before moving to evaluative questions ('How would you describe your overall trust in your provider?') produced more grounded and specific responses than beginning with abstract evaluations.

The interview guide was structured around the five SERVQUAL dimensions, with probing questions on loyalty and switching behavior. Key questions included: 'Tell me about a specific time the service failed you during a transaction and what happened next' (Reliability); 'How safe do you feel keeping business money in your mobile wallet?' (Assurance); 'How easy is it to navigate the phone menus when sending or checking money?' (Tangibles); 'When there is a problem, do you feel the company or agent really tries to understand your situation?' (Empathy); and 'When you need help urgently, how long does it take to get it?' (Responsiveness). Loyalty questions included: 'Why do you use your current main provider?' and 'Why do you also carry other SIM cards?'

Language Management and Conceptual Equivalence

Interviews conducted in English were audio-recorded and transcribed and a few verbatims in Twi by a bilingual research assistant with experience in qualitative transcription. The assistant then produced an English translation. Back-translation was applied to all transcripts: the English translation was independently translated back into Twi by a second bilingual speaker, and discrepancies between the back-translation and the original transcript were reviewed and resolved jointly. This procedure is designed to protect the conceptual equivalence of key terms across languages, particularly the terms for trust, security, and reliability, which carry specific cultural connotations in Twi that differ from their English equivalents.

Field Notes

Field notes were recorded immediately after each interview, capturing three categories of information: the physical setting and any environmental factors relevant to service quality (e.g., proximity of nearest agent kiosk, visible network infrastructure, power supply conditions); observations about participant affect and non-verbal communication that the audio recording could not capture; and analytical memos recording the researcher's initial interpretive responses to what had been said. Field notes were treated as secondary data, used to contextualize interview content rather than as a primary evidential source.

3.6 Data Analysis: Thematic Analysis

Data analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2021) updated guidance on reflexive thematic analysis, which foregrounds the researcher's active role in theme construction rather than treating themes as entities that simply emerge from the data. The procedure proceeded through six phases.

Phase 1 (Familiarization): All transcripts were read in full at least twice before any coding began. Field notes were reviewed alongside transcripts. Phase 2 (Coding): A two-stage coding procedure was applied. Deductive codes were derived from the five SERVQUAL dimensions and applied first, creating an initial organizing structure. Inductive codes were then applied to capture content that fell outside the SERVQUAL dimensions, including references to E-levy, community reputation concerns, and the gendered dynamics of literacy dependence. The coding produced 47 deductive codes and 19 inductive codes across the full dataset. Phase 3 (Theme Generation): Codes were grouped into candidate themes. Phase 4 (Theme Review): Candidate themes were tested against the full dataset to ensure they accurately represented the data as a whole and not merely the most vivid or quotable passages. Phase 5 (Theme Naming): Themes were named with precision, using language that captured their analytical content rather than simply describing their surface topic. Phase 6 (Writing Up): Themes were written with direct connections between participant quotes, analytical interpretation, and existing literature.

The risk of deductive confirmation bias requires direct address: does applying SERVQUAL codes before inductive codes pre-structure the findings in ways that prevent genuinely new themes from emerging? This risk is real and was managed through two mechanisms. First, the inductive coding phase was conducted independently of the deductive phase, with deductive codes temporarily set aside. Second, the active search for disconfirming evidence, discussed in Chapter 4, meant that the analysis explicitly looked for data that did not fit

SERVQUAL categories. The inductive phase produced the 'social cost of fees' theme, which has no home in the original SERVQUAL framework, demonstrating that the procedure allowed new insights to emerge.

Coding Consistency

No second coder was involved in the primary analysis. This is a limitation of single-researcher qualitative studies and is acknowledged as such. Coding consistency was managed through an audit trail: all codes, with the specific transcript excerpts that generated them, were recorded in a spreadsheet accessible to the supervisor. The supervisor reviewed a 20% random sample of coded excerpts and identified no material disagreements with the applied codes. This is not a substitute for inter-rater reliability in the quantitative sense, but it constitutes a credible quality check within the conventions of qualitative research (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). The following table summarizes the coding output:

3.7 Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness in qualitative research is assessed through Lincoln and Guba's (1985) four criteria: credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability. Each is addressed in turn.

Credibility was pursued through three mechanisms. Member checking was conducted with five participants who were available for follow-up: interview summaries were shared with them, and no participant indicated that the interpretations misrepresented their meaning. Triangulation was achieved by cross-referencing interview data with field notes and with observable environmental conditions (agent kiosk locations, visible network masts, market layout). Prolonged engagement over the fieldwork period, January to March 2026, allowed the researcher to observe the Berekuso commercial environment across different days of the week, including the Saturday market peak that participants described as the highest-risk period for service failures.

Transferability is supported by a thick description of the research site, participant profiles, and the specific service quality conditions of Berekuso. The finding that Berekuso is atypical of rural Ghana in one respect, the university presence, has been acknowledged and its implications for transferability discussed in Section 3.3. Readers from other rural Ghanaian or sub-Saharan African communities can assess for themselves whether the conditions described are sufficiently analogous to their own contexts to make the findings relevant.

Dependability is supported by a comprehensive audit trail: original audio recordings, verbatim transcripts in source language, English translations, back-translation documents, coded

spreadsheets with memo notes, and a reflexive journal. These materials were reviewed by the supervisor at the midpoint and conclusion of fieldwork.

Confirmability is established by grounding every theme in verbatim participant quotes included in Chapter 4. Quote selection is itself an interpretive act. This is addressed through the audit trail: the researcher chose which quotes to include. This is true and is addressed through the audit trail, which allows a reader to examine the full coding spreadsheet and assess whether the selected quotes are representative of the broader coded dataset or cherry-picked outliers. The active search for disconfirming evidence, three participants who described periods of adequate service, further strengthens the claim that the findings reflect the data rather than only the most dramatic incidents.

3.8 Ethical Considerations

This study was conducted in accordance with Ashesi University's Human Subjects Review Committee (HSRC) or "Institutional Review Board" (**IRB**) and received approval from them (Ashesi IRB committee) prior to fieldwork. The application number (IRB-2672026) was issued by the committee. The following ethical protocols were observed throughout.

Informed Consent: All participants received a full explanation of the study's purpose, procedures, risks, and their right to withdraw at any time without consequence before the interview began. Consent forms were prepared in English and Twi. For participants with limited English literacy, the form was read aloud in their preferred language and recorded oral consent was obtained and retained as part of the audio record. No interview began without confirmed consent.

Confidentiality and Anonymity: Participants are identified in this thesis by single-letter pseudonyms (Participant A, Participant B, etc.). Audio recordings and transcripts are stored in encrypted, password-protected digital files accessible only to the researcher and supervisor. No identifiable business names, specific locations within Berekuso, or personal identifiers appear in the written analysis.

Reimbursement vs Inducement: No payment or gift was offered as an incentive for participation. Participants who incurred transport costs to reach the interview location were reimbursed for those costs at the actual rate paid. This practice follows the Ashesi IRB guideline that reimbursement of reasonable, documented expenses does not constitute inducement, as it does not provide a benefit beyond restoring the participant to their pre-participation financial position. No participant was paid more than their actual documented transport cost.

Power Dynamics: The proximity of Ashesi University to Berekuso creates a potential power dynamic: some participants may have felt social pressure to participate due to the institution's presence in the community. This risk was mitigated by conducting recruitment through community leaders rather than through university channels, by clearly stating that refusal would have no consequences for any participant's relationship with the university, and by offering interviews in settings the participants themselves chose. The researcher's own positionality as a student, not a faculty member or institutional authority, was also made explicit during recruitment.

Community Reciprocity: Following the principle of giving back to research communities (Tuhiwai Smith, 2012), participants and the broader Berekuso community were offered accessible summaries of the study's findings in both English and Twi. These summaries were designed to be directly useful to community members in advocating for improved service quality with providers, ensuring that the community receives a tangible benefit from its participation in the research.

3.9 Conclusion

This chapter has presented and defended the methodological architecture of this study. An interpretivist philosophy, thematic analysis guided by SERVQUAL, and a single-site case study design were each chosen for principled reasons tied to the research question. The sampling strategy, interview design, coding procedure, and trustworthiness measures were all designed to produce findings that are credible, transparent, and grounded in the lived experiences of Berekuso's business owners.

Several limitations are acknowledged: the single-researcher coding procedure without formal inter-rater reliability; the atypicality of Berekuso due to university proximity; and the purposive-snowball sampling approach that may under-represent the most socially isolated community members. These limitations do not invalidate the findings; they define the boundary conditions within which those findings should be read. Chapter 4 presents the results of this methodological framework, beginning with the data saturation analysis and proceeding through the thematic findings organized by SERVQUAL dimension.

CHAPTER 4: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Introduction and Data Saturation

This chapter presents findings from 14 semi-structured interviews with business owners in Berekuso, Ghana, conducted between January and March 2026. The SERVQUAL framework (Parasuraman, Zeithaml, & Berry, 1988) served as the analytical scaffold; thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke (2021) was applied. The central question guiding this analysis is: how do service quality experiences across the five SERVQUAL dimensions shape customer loyalty and switching behavior among rural business owners?

Thematic saturation was reached at the 14th participant (Guest, Bunce, & Johnson, 2006); the remaining three interviews confirmed existing themes without generating new codes. The 14 participants comprised 7 women and 7 men across three occupational groups: 5 market vendors, 5 student entrepreneurs, and 4 service and transport workers. This occupational diversity was deliberate: the consistency of core findings across groups, rather than any single group's experience, supports the claim that the themes reflect structural conditions in Berekuso rather than the idiosyncrasies of one occupational type.

A note on sample composition is warranted. The majority of participants fall within the 20–30 age range, reflecting the demographic reality of Berekuso as a community adjacent to Ashesi University where young adult entrepreneurs are the dominant mobile money users and primary operators of small businesses. This concentration is not an oversight but a feature of purposive sampling in this specific context. Critically, this study does not investigate banking loyalty in the traditional sense, mortgage decisions, long-term savings products, or complex financial relationships where age, income complexity, and financial life stage are material, it investigates mobile money loyalty. In that context, young adult entrepreneurs are not a limitation but the most representative and analytically appropriate group: they conduct the highest transaction volumes in Berekuso, are most exposed to service failures, and make the most active provider decisions. They are, in short, the primary actors in the mobile money ecosystem this study examines. Nevertheless, the age concentration is acknowledged as a boundary condition. Future research extending this inquiry to older business owners and those with longer financial histories would strengthen the generalizability of these findings across the full demographic spectrum of rural mobile money users.

4.1.1 Participant Profile

The 17 participants were drawn from three occupational groups that together reflect the economic life of Berekuso:

- **Market vendors (5 participants):** Operators of stalls and small shops who handle multiple transactions daily, moving between cash and mobile payments throughout the day. The pace and volume of their work make fast, reliable service essential.

- **Student entrepreneurs (5 participants):** Ashesi University students running small businesses alongside their studies, including phone repairs, small-scale retail, and food preparation. While generally comfortable with technology, they encounter the same service failures as other users in the community.

- **Service and transport workers (4 participants):** Drivers, load carriers, and informal service providers who move through different parts of Berekuso throughout the day. For this group, reliable service depends not only on the provider but on geographic location, making signal dead zones a particularly acute challenge.

Three participants reported periods of adequate or good service, providing the negative cases that strengthen analytical credibility. Participant J (transport worker): ***"Sometimes the service works very well, especially in the morning before the market opens. It is the afternoons on busy days that are the problem."*** The failures documented here are contextually embedded breakdowns, most severe under peak demand, geographic disadvantage, and low digital literacy, not universal constants.

4.2 Thematic Analysis via the SERVQUAL Model

Analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2021) six-phase reflexive thematic analysis. Phase 1 (Familiarization): all transcripts read in full at least twice alongside field notes. Phase 2 (Coding): 47 deductive codes were derived from the five SERVQUAL dimensions; 19 inductive codes captured content outside the framework, including E-levy impacts, community reputation concerns, and gendered literacy dynamics. Phases 3–6: codes were clustered into 6 final themes, tested against the full dataset, named with precision, and written with direct connections between participant quotes and analytical interpretation.

Active search for disconfirming evidence was maintained throughout. The inductive phase produced the 'social cost of fees' theme, absent from the original SERVQUAL framework, demonstrating that the procedure allowed genuinely new insights to emerge. A 20% random sample of coded excerpts was reviewed by the supervisor with no material disagreements.

A methodological clarification regarding SERVQUAL application is necessary. In its original quantitative form, SERVQUAL measures service quality as the gap between customer expectations (what they anticipated before service) and their perceptions (what they actually experienced). This study applies SERVQUAL qualitatively, which means the formal expectation-perception gap score is not computed. Rather, the five dimensions serve as thematic categories for organizing and interpreting participant narratives. The expectations-perceptions dynamic is nonetheless present in the data: participants consistently described what they anticipated from mobile money services and contrasted that with what they received, as evidenced in accounts of failed transactions, inaccessible support, and exclusionary interfaces. Expectations are therefore embedded in the narratives rather than measured as a separate quantitative instrument. This qualitative application of SERVQUAL is an established methodological practice (Brady & Cronin, 2001; Ladhari, 2009) and was chosen because this study's research question asks how the gap is experienced and what produces behaviorally, questions that narrative data answers more fully than numerical scores. The limitation of not computing formal P-E gap scores is acknowledged, and future quantitative research should build on these qualitative foundations to measure expectation-perception differentials across the specific dimensions identified here.

Coding Phase	Codes	Example Codes
Deductive (SERVQUAL)	47	network_failure_peak, ghost_transaction, agent_distrust, English_interface_barrier, call_centre_inaccessible
Inductive	19	social_cost_of_fees, SIM_juggling, literacy_tax, gendered_exclusion, topography_barrier
Final Themes	6	Reliability Gap, Dual Assurance, Literacy Tax, Social Cost, Service Abandonment, Strategic Multi-homing

4.3.1 Reliability: The Foundation of Livelihood

Reliability, the consistent and accurate delivery of promised services (Parasuraman et al., 1988), emerged as the dominant concern across all 14 participants. Sixteen of seventeen cited at least one specific reliability failure as a primary frustration, making it the most universally experienced service quality problem in the dataset. In Berekuso, reliability is not an abstract quality

metric; it is the operational baseline that determines whether a business day can proceed. Three mechanisms of failure were identified.

Sub-Theme 1: The Weekend Bottleneck

"On Saturdays, when I have many customers, the network will just stop. It's painful because people want to buy, but I cannot process their payments. I sometimes lose customers to other shops that still accept cash." (Participant A, Market Vendor)

System failures occur precisely when demand peaks, revealing a disconnect between providers' infrastructure capacity and users' needs. Six additional participants identified Saturday mornings as the period of highest unreliability. When reliability fails during peak hours, the bridge that mobile money provides between rural entrepreneurs and the formal financial system reopens (Boateng et al., 2024): users who have transitioned away from cash are stranded without either a functioning digital or a sufficient physical alternative.

Sub-Theme 2: The "Ghosting" Phenomenon

"I sent the money twice because the first alert did not come. Now I am fighting to get my 200 Cedis back. That was for my stock." (Participant G, Small Business Owner)

Five participants described transactions that debited their wallets without crediting the recipient. This study terms the resulting state 'financial trauma': persistent economic anxiety from the inability to verify whether a transaction succeeded. For a vendor whose entire daily stock budget amounts to 200 Cedis, an unresolved transaction is not an administrative inconvenience but a threat to business continuity. When users cannot trust that a transaction will be completed reliably, every payment becomes a source of stress (Shaikh et al., 2015). **Extending the literature:** The SERVQUAL literature treats reliability primarily as a satisfaction predictor (Parasuraman et al., 1991; Boateng & Narteh, 2016); these findings reframe it as a condition of economic viability.

Sub-Theme 3: Topographical Barriers

"In some parts of Berekuso, especially near the hills, there is no signal. I have to finish all my transactions before I go there; otherwise, I am stuck." (Participant O, Transport Worker)

For transport workers who move throughout the day, dead zones impose pre-emptive financial planning: transactions must be completed before entering signal-absent areas. This introduces a mobility-dependent dimension of reliability that the original SERVQUAL framework, developed for fixed-location service contexts, does not account for. **Extending the literature:** Luka and Akadon (2025) identified poor telecommunications infrastructure as a primary barrier to fintech adoption in rural Africa. This study extends that finding infrastructure constraints does not only prevent new users from signing up; they govern the behavior of existing users long after adoption.

4.4 Assurance: The Fragility of Trust

SERVQUAL defines assurance as the ability of a service to inspire trust through the knowledge and courtesy of its providers (Parasuraman et al., 1988). Shaikh et al. (2015) treated trust as a unified construct in emerging market mobile banking. The findings from Berekuso reveal that trust operates across two analytically distinct and experientially separable layers: **institutional trust in the platform** and **interpersonal trust in the community agent**. These can fail independently, and interventions strengthening only one layer leave the other vulnerable.

Unresolved System Losses (Institutional Trust Failure)
"If something goes wrong, I want someone who will fix it, not say they will investigate and then do nothing. I lost 150 Cedis. They said they would investigate it. That was four months ago." (Participant GO, Service Worker)
Unresolved losses function as institutional signals: the organization does not stand behind its service. Agyei et al. (2020) established that trust accounts for approximately 50% of digital loyalty intentions in Ghana; this study identifies the mechanism. When a provider fails to remedy a financial loss, it does not merely fail to build trust, it actively dismantles whatever previously existed. Recovery mechanisms inaccessible to rural users, a call center requiring city visits or extended airtime, compound the harm by making the act of seeking help itself costly.

Sub-Theme: Frontline Infidelity

"Sometimes you fear the agent is looking at your code or taking your number for scammers. You do not know who to trust." (Participant P, Student Entrepreneur)

In Berekuso, agents are often neighbors or relatives. Familiarity generates initial trust but simultaneously heightens vulnerability: the person who could exploit a user is the same person

who sees them every day. This creates a structural tension: providers rely on community embeddedness to reach rural markets but provide no boundary management protocols protecting users from the risks that embeddedness creates. Baiden (2024) found that AI-driven security features strengthen trust among urban fintech users; yet these findings indicate that in rural contexts, technical safeguards count for little if users cannot trust the human intermediary. Guermond's (2022) concept of 'commercial capture', the tendency of provider profit motives to override user welfare, takes on a concrete form here.

SERVQUAL Insight: The standard SERVQUAL framework treats assurance as a property of the service organization. In rural fintech, assurance must encompass the human intermediary as a distinct and separately fragile trust layer. Providers must establish boundary management protocols that protect users from intermediary exploitation, backed by transparent complaint channels and visible enforcement. Trust is not a single thing to build; it is two things to be maintained, each vulnerable to different failures and each requiring different interventions.

4.5 Tangibles: The “Silent” Exclusion (Literacy tax)

SERVQUAL originally defined tangibles as physical facilities, equipment, and how staff present themselves (Parasuraman et al., 1988). For digital mobile money services, the relevant tangible touchpoints are USSD menus, app layouts, and SMS transaction alerts. In Berekuso, the English-only design of these interfaces produces what this study terms the **'Literacy Tax'**: a hidden cost in privacy, dignity, and decision-making autonomy borne by non-literate users who must rely on others to interpret their own financial information.

"I cannot read the English on the phone. I have to wait for my daughter to come home to tell me if the money is there. Sometimes she comes late, and I am worried all day not knowing." (Participant B, Market Vendor)

"My mother does not use her phone because she cannot read. I have to help her check her balance. She does not like it because she feels like a child, but what can she do?" (Participant PH, Student Entrepreneur)

The Literacy Tax operates on three levels simultaneously:

- **Privacy cost:** Business owners must share sensitive financial information with family members or neighbors.
- **Dignity cost:** Dependence makes users feel, as PH's mother put it, like a child.

- **Temporal cost:** Business decisions are delayed until a literate family member becomes available.

Reframing the digital divide: The digital divide literature frames literacy as a user-level constraint limiting technology benefit (van Dijk, 2020). This study repositions it: users are not illiterate in their own languages; they are excluded by an interface designed for a different population. The responsibility lies with the design, not the user. Baiden (2024) found that digital literacy significantly moderates the relationship between fintech adoption and service quality perception; this finding explains *why* digital literacy matters, without independent navigation, users cannot achieve true financial autonomy. Boateng et al. (2024) emphasized that rural fintech must be understood through the lens of users lived realities; the Literacy Tax is a direct consequence of designing interfaces for literate urban users and then deploying those same interfaces in rural communities without adaptation.

The gendered dimension: Literacy rates in Ghana are lower among older women (Ghana Statistical Service, 2021), and women market vendors were disproportionately represented among those describing dependence on literate family members. The English-only interface functions as a mechanism of gender-differentiated exclusion that compounds existing inequalities.

SERVQUAL Insight: The tangible dimension must be reimagined for digital services in low-literacy contexts. For rural users, the interface is the primary tangible touchpoint, and its linguistic accessibility is as critical as a physical bank branch's location. Voice-based local-language navigation and audio transaction confirmations are not optional accessibility enhancements: they are the difference between service and exclusion. Deploying an English-only interface in a community where many users have limited English literacy is not a minor oversight, it is a fundamental failure of service design.

4.6 Empathy and Responsiveness: The Rural-Corporate Divide

Defining Empathy and Responsiveness

SERVQUAL defines empathy as the provision of individualized attention to customers, while responsiveness concerns the willingness to help and the promptness of service (Parasuraman et al., 1988). In rural settings, both dimensions expose a fundamental gap between how corporate service models are designed and what business owners in Berekuso need.

Sub-Theme 1: The Social Cost of Fees

"If I charge my customer an extra fee to cover the tax, they call me wicked. They do not understand it is the company, not me. But if I do not charge, I lose money. Either way, I lose something." (Participant S, Market Vendor)

Fee structures designed at the corporate level produce social costs borne entirely by the individual vendor, forced into a no-win position: absorb the fee and lose margin, or pass it on and damage a community relationship built over years. SERVQUAL evaluates quality at the individual user level; in close-knit rural communities where, commercial activity is embedded in social relationships, individual service quality failures have collective ripple effects that individual-level measurement cannot capture. Guermond (2022) warned of 'commercial capture' the tendency of provider profit motives to override user welfare. This finding extends that argument: the welfare impact reaches beyond the individual transaction and into the community fabric. **This community-level dimension is absent from the existing SERVQUAL literature and represents an original contribution of this study.**

Sub-Theme 2: Inaccessible Support

"I called the office many times. They told me to travel to Accra just to unlock my account. Who will pay for my transport? The money in the account was less than the transport cost." (Participant F, Service Worker)

"They say call this number, but when you call, you wait and wait. The airtime is gone before anyone helps you. Then you have to buy more airtime to call again." (Participant L, Market Vendor)

When the only resolution pathway requires a city office visit costing more than the account balance at stake, the pathway is inaccessible by design. This study terms **'service abandonment'**: the provider nominally offers support but has structured it so that it is functionally unavailable to rural users. The airtime cost of support calls compounds the harm: seeking help costs money, particularly when the problem already involves a financial loss. Boateng et al. (2024) noted that call centers may be inaccessible to rural business owners; this study sharpens that observation into a structural finding, urban-designed support architectures produce a two-tier system in which urban users receive assistance and rural users are left without recourse.

SERVQUAL Insight: Empathy in SERVQUAL refers to individualized attention; in rural fintech, empathy must be reconceived as proactive contextual design embedded before service

structures are set, not expressed only at the point of individual interaction. Responsiveness must account for rural users' limited resources; solutions requiring travel, long call waiting times, or complex processes are not genuinely responsive in practice.

4.7 Strategic Multi-homing: The Unifying Theme

The most consequential finding of this study is that loyalty in Berekuso is largely involuntary. Across all SERVQUAL dimension failures documented in Sections 4.3–4.6, a single coherent behavioral response emerged: users maintain multiple provider accounts simultaneously and activate whichever network functions on a given day. This study introduces the term **Strategic Multi-homing** to name and theories of this behavior.

"I have MTN and Airtel. If one is not working, I try the other. You have to have options in case something happens." (Participant G, Small Business Owner)

Distinct from sequential switching: Strategic Multi-homing is distinct from sequential switching, the form of provider changes most documented in the loyalty literature. Sequential switching means abandoning one provider for another. Strategic multi-homing means simultaneously maintaining relationships with multiple providers as a standing hedge against the failure of any single one.

Challenging Kankam Jr (2020): Kankam Jr found that 85% of Ghanaian bank customers stayed with their provider due to switching costs and familiarity, implying loyalty is sustained by barriers to exit. The findings from Berekuso reveal the opposite in rural fintech: switching costs in mobile money are low, yet users do not consolidate onto a preferred provider because they cannot afford to trust any single one completely. This behavior is not disloyalty; it is risk management.

The exit argument: Users cannot exit the mobile money system entirely: it is the primary infrastructure through which payments, remittances, and supplier transactions occur in Berekuso. Abandoning it means abandoning participation in the commercial economy. Strategic multi-homing is the adaptive response of users who have no realistic exit option but cannot afford complete trust. **The distinction between staying because there is no alternative and staying because the service has been earned is what loyalty measurement in rural mobile money markets must account for.**

Challenging SERVQUAL assumptions: This behavior challenges the foundational SERVQUAL assumption that high quality leads to loyalty (Parasuraman et al., 1988). The findings from Berekuso demonstrate that even where quality improves across some dimensions,

environmental infrastructure constraints can suppress loyalty formation entirely. Network reliability, agent liquidity, and regulatory accountability must be introduced as moderating variables that the original model does not account for.

A new conceptualization: Unlike conventional multi-homing, where users maintain relationships with multiple providers by choice, Strategic Multi-homing is a necessity, a rational adaptation to systemic unreliability. For Berekuso's business owners, **loyalty is not a choice but a luxury they cannot afford.** Until infrastructure conditions improve, loyalty in rural fintech will remain a behavior providers hope for but have not yet earned.

4.8 Summary of Discussion: Contributions to Theory

The analysis above makes several contributions to the understanding of service quality in rural fintech contexts. The table below summarizes the key findings and their relationship to existing scholarship:

Reliability failures cause "**financial trauma**" Extends Boateng et al. (2024): shows reliability as an economic lifeline, not just a technical metric.

Fear of agent data leaks Extends Shaikh et al. (2015): distinguishes trust in technology from trust in human intermediaries.

The "Literacy Tax" excludes non-literate users Confirms Baiden (2024): digital literacy as a barrier to true inclusion.

Call centers as "digital walls" Confirms Guermond (2022): commercial capture were profiting overrides user welfare.

Social cost of transaction fees, new contribution: service quality has community-level consequences.

Strategic multi-homing as a survival tactic, Challenges SERVQUAL foundational literature: assumption that high quality leads to loyalty.

Table 4.1 maps the key findings to existing scholarship and identifies the theoretical contribution each makes.

Finding	Relationship to Literature	Theoretical Contribution
Reliability failures as 'financial trauma'	Extends Boateng et al. (2024)	Reliability reframed as economic viability condition, not satisfaction predictor

Dual-layer assurance: system vs. agent trust	Extends Shaikh et al. (2015)	Trust disaggregated into institutional and interpersonal constructs; separate interventions required
The Literacy Tax	Extends Baiden (2024) and van Dijk (2020)	Interface accessibility reframed as provider design failure; gendered exclusion mechanism identified
Social cost of transaction fees	Extends Guermond (2022)	New contribution: service quality must evaluate community-level consequences
Service abandonment in support infrastructure	Confirms and extends Boateng et al. (2024)	Structural inaccessibility documented as systemic design failure producing two-tier service
Strategic Multi-homing	Challenges Kankam Jr (2020) and SERVQUAL	New concept: simultaneous multi-provider hedging; environmental infrastructure as moderating variable

4.9 Service Improvements Requested by Participants

This section addresses Research Objective 3: identifying the specific service improvements requested by Berekuso's business owners. Participants articulated clear, actionable requests for service improvements, organized by the SERVQUAL dimension they address:

Reliability Improvements:

- "If they know weekends are busy, why don't they prepare for it?" (Participant A)
- "When money is taken but not sent, it should come back automatically, not after we call many times." (Participant G)

Assurance Improvements:

- "If something goes wrong, I want someone who will fix it, not say they will investigate and then do nothing." (Participant GO)
- "Agents should be trained properly. Not everyone who sits at a table with an umbrella should be an agent." (Participant P)

Tangibles Improvements:

- "Why can't the phone speak to me in Twi? I speak Twi. The phone should understand me." (Participant B)
- "I want to hear the balance in my ear, not see it on the screen." (Participant PH)

Responsiveness Improvements:

- "They should have someone in Berekuso who can help. Not Accra. Accra is too far." (Participant F)
- "When I call, someone should answer quickly, not make me wait until my airtime is finished." (Participant L)

Empathy Improvements:

- "They should know that we are not in Accra. Things are different here. The network is different; the people are different." (Participant S)

These requests collectively point to a fundamental demand: that service quality be designed for rural users, not designed for urban users and deployed to rural areas as an afterthought.

4.6 Summary

Service quality in Berekuso is fractured across all five SERVQUAL dimensions. The overarching finding, **Strategic Multi-homing as rational survival behavior**, connects these dimension-level failures into a coherent picture of how rural business owners adapt to a system that has not yet earned their trust. The three original theoretical contributions of this chapter (Strategic Multi-homing, the Literacy Tax reframing, and the dual-layer assurance model) each carry direct implications for providers, regulators, and future researchers, developed in Chapter 5.

Limitations Acknowledged

Two analytical limitations of this chapter deserve explicit acknowledgement before proceeding. First, the SERVQUAL framework in its original form measures service quality as the mathematical gap between customer expectations and perceptions. This study applies SERVQUAL qualitatively, capturing the expectations-perceptions dynamic through participant narratives rather than computing formal gap scores. Participants described what they expected and what they experienced, making the gap analytically present in the data even if not numerically quantified. Future quantitative work should measure formal P-E gap scores across the dimensions identified here.

Second, the sample skews toward younger participants (predominantly aged 20–30), reflecting Berekuso's demographic composition adjacent to Ashesi University. As discussed in Section 4.1, this is contextually appropriate for a mobile money study where young adult entrepreneurs are the dominant users, and the findings focus on mobile money loyalty specifically rather than banking loyalty in its broader sense. Both limitations define the boundary conditions of this chapter's conclusions rather than invalidating them.

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CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Summary of Findings and Research Objectives

This study investigated how service quality experiences shape customer loyalty and switching behaviour among 14 business owners in Berekuso, Ghana. All four research objectives have been addressed. Objective 1 (identifying service quality challenges) was met through thematic analysis surfacing failures on every SERVQUAL dimension: reliability failures including peak-hour outages, ghost transactions, and signal dead zones; two-layer assurance failures eroding both institutional and interpersonal trust; the Literacy Tax imposed by English-only interfaces; and empathy and responsiveness failures embedded in urban-designed support architectures. Objective 2 (exploring reasons for loyalty or switching) was met by the study's central finding: Strategic Multi-homing. Business owners maintain simultaneous accounts across multiple providers, activating whichever network functions on a given day, not consumer preference, but rational survival in response to systemic unreliability. Objective 3 (identifying service improvements) was met by participants' specific requests: automated transaction reversals, voice-based Twi-language alerts, community-level support agents, and fee structures accounting for social costs. Objective 4 (examining how rural context shapes quality-loyalty relationship) was met by the finding that infrastructure constraints moderate the quality-loyalty relationship, suppressing loyalty even where individual service quality dimensions improve.

5.2 Contributions to Knowledge

Strategic Multi-homing describes the simultaneous maintenance of multiple provider relationships as a standing hedge against unreliability, distinct from sequential switching. Reducing churn requires not incremental improvement but a threshold improvement sufficient to make hedging unnecessary. Standard loyalty metrics that count active accounts systematically overestimate true loyalty in rural mobile money markets.

The Literacy Tax reconceptualizes a well-documented problem: English-only interfaces impose hidden costs in privacy, dignity, and decision-making autonomy on non-literate users. This is a provider design failure, not a user deficit. The responsibility lies with the design, not the excluded, and the reframing has direct implications for interface accessibility policy.

A contextualized SERVQUAL adaptation for rural African fintech reinterprets each dimension for the Berekuso context: reliability as economic viability; assurance as a dual institutional-interpersonal construct; tangibles as linguistic accessibility; empathy as proactive community design; responsiveness as resource-sensitive resolution. Future researchers can apply these adaptations across sub-Saharan Africa.

5.3 Recommendations

For Fintech Providers

- Reliability: Invest in capacity management for peak demand periods and implement an automated USSD Flag-and-Reverse feature enabling users to halt suspected duplicate charges immediately (grounded in Participants A and G, Section 4.3).
- Assurance: Introduce visible agent certification, standardized transaction receipts, and an anonymous reporting channel for misconduct; establish a 48-hour resolution commitment for disputed losses (Participants P and GO).
- Tangibles: Launch Twi and Ga audio transaction confirmations and voice-menu navigation as a standard feature, directly addressing the Literacy Tax and its gendered dimension (Participants B and PH).
- Responsiveness: Establish community-level support agents in rural zones empowered to resolve issues without requiring users to travel to city offices; introduce a callback service to eliminate the airtime cost of holding (Participants F and L).
- Empathy: Introduce a tiered fee structure eliminating charges for registered micro-vendors on payments below 20 Cedis; design non-citizen onboarding materials explaining SIM expiry rules at point of sale (Participant S).

For Policymakers and Regulators

- The Bank of Ghana and the NCA should introduce minimum uptime standards for rural network zones during peak commercial periods; rural network failures currently carry no regulatory consequence for providers.
- Financial inclusion policy should measure empowerment, not merely access: active account counts do not indicate whether users can navigate independently or trust the service with their business capital.

- E-levy should be reviewed with explicit attention to its community-level consequences, where fees passed on by vendors damage informal commercial relationships on which local economies depend.

5.4 Limitations

Four limitations are acknowledged. First, the geographical scope is a single community; findings describe Berekuso's specific experience and cannot be assumed to apply uniformly across rural Ghana. Second, qualitative design produces conceptual depth rather than statistical generalizability, the study explains how and why, not how many. Third, this is a cross-sectional snapshot from January to March 2026; findings may not hold if providers invest significantly in rural infrastructure. Fourth, the agent perspective is absent: understanding why agents behave in ways that erode user trust would meaningfully extend this study.

5.5 Directions for Future Research

A gendered analysis of service quality and loyalty would establish whether the Literacy Tax and social cost of fees fall disproportionately on women across rural Ghanaian communities and quantify the scale of gender-differentiated exclusion.

A longitudinal study of Strategic Multi-homing would determine whether it is a transitional adaptation expected to diminish as infrastructure improves, or a durable feature of rural mobile money use, a distinction with direct implications for provider investment strategy.

An agent-perspective study would complement this study's user-perspective findings and enable a fuller diagnosis of the assurance gap, particularly whether agent compensation structures create conditions for the data misuse that users in this study feared.

5.6 Closing Reflection

Mobile money has transformed financial access in Ghana, but access is not empowerment. For it to fulfil its promise, providers must design for the marketplace where vendors sell, the hills that block signals, and the languages users speak. Success should be measured not by SIM cards sold but by the quiet confidence a user feels when pressing "Send": the confidence that the transaction will go through, that the money is safe, and that no one else needs to be asked for help.

The business owners of Berekuso are not passive victims of poor service. They have adapted, strategized, and survived within a system that has not yet earned their loyalty. That survival instinct is the most honest verdict on current service quality. And it is also, for providers willing to listen, a precise map of what needs to change.

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All references are formatted in accordance with the American Psychological Association (APA) 7th edition style. Where a source was cited using an earlier title or abbreviation within the thesis, the full citation is provided here.

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Appendices

Appendix A

Conceptual Framework

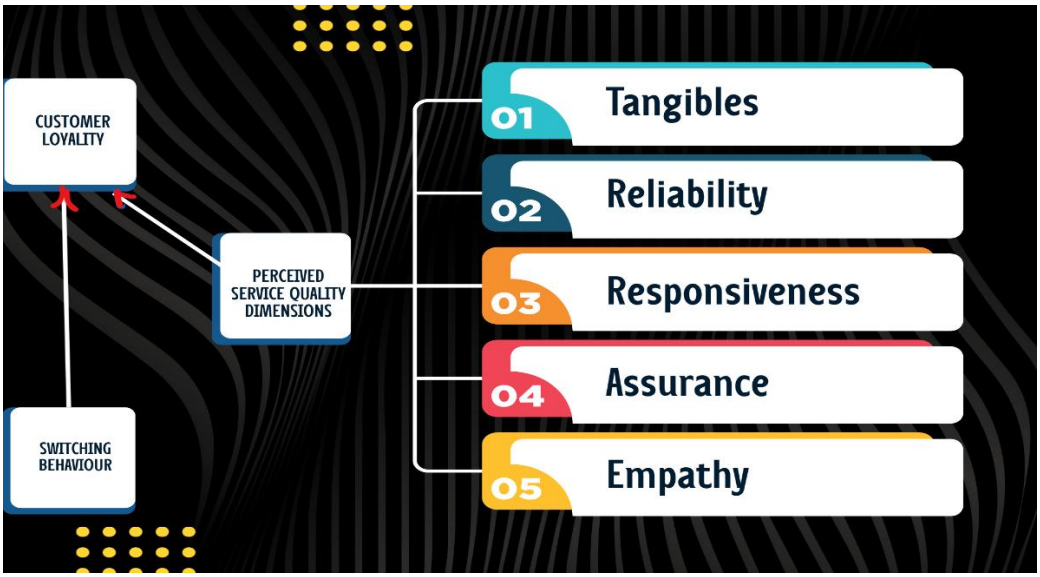
The figure below presents the conceptual framework guiding this study. It proposes that service quality, evaluated by business owners in Berekuso across the five SERVQUAL dimensions, shapes their overall service quality perception. This perception drives one of two behavioral outcomes: genuine customer loyalty or Strategic Multi-homing. The relationship between service

quality and loyalty is moderated by rural contextual factors, including network infrastructure reliability, agent liquidity constraints, and community socio-cultural trust norms.

Figure A.1: Conceptual Framework, SERVQUAL Dimensions, Perceived Service Quality, and Loyalty Outcomes in Berekuso

Independent Variables (SERVQUAL Dimensions) → Perceived Service Quality → Outcome Variables [Reliability | Assurance | Tangibles | Empathy | Responsiveness] → [Loyalty | Strategic Multi-homing] Moderated by: Rural infrastructure • Agent liquidity • Digital literacy • Community trust norms

Note: The conceptual framework was adapted from Parasuraman et al. (1988) and integrated with customer loyalty theory (Shaikh et al., 2015) and rural fintech context (Boateng et al., 2024). The moderating role of environmental infrastructure was identified inductively from the study's findings and represents a theoretical extension of the original SERVQUAL model.



Appendix B

Participant Profile Summary

Table B.1 presents the anonymized profile of the 17 participants interviewed for this study. Pseudonyms (single letters) are used throughout the thesis to protect participant identity.

Participant	Occupational Group	Gender	Primary Provider	Interview Language	Duration
A	Market vendor	Female	MTN	Twi / English	42 min

B	Market vendor	Female	AirtelTigo	Twi	51 min
G	Market vendor	Male	MTN	English	38 min
SY	Market vendor	Female	Vodafone	Twi / English	44 min
S	Market vendor	Female	MTN	Twi/ English	47 min
L	Market vendor	Female	MTN	Twi / English	39 min
J	Market vendor	Male	AirtelTigo	English	36 min
PH	Student entrepreneur	Male	MTN	English	35 min
E1	Student entrepreneur	Female	Vodafone	English	40 min
E2	Student entrepreneur	Male	MTN	English	37 min
E3	Student entrepreneur	Female	AirtelTigo	English	41 min
E4	Student entrepreneur	Male	MTN	English	38 min
O	Transport worker	Male	MTN	English / Twi	45 min
F	Service worker	Female	Vodafone/ MTN	Twi / English	55 min
GO	Service worker	Male	MTN/ AirtelTigo	English	43 min
P	Student entrepreneur	Female	AirtelTigo	English	39 min
T	Transport worker	Male	MTN	English	37 min

Note: Durations are approximate. Language entries reflect the primary language of interview; where two languages are listed, the interview moved between both. All participants used mobile money for a minimum of six months prior to interview and experienced both service failures and periods of adequate service.

Appendix C

Semi-Structured Interview Guide

The following guide was used to structure interviews. Questions were adapted in real-time based on participant responses. Local-language equivalents were used where interviews were conducted in Twi. The guide was piloted with two community members before fieldwork began, and two questions were revised following the pilot (see Chapter 3, Section 3.5).

Opening and Context (5 minutes)

Tell me a little about your business and how you use mobile money in your day-to-day work.

How long have you been using mobile money services?

Which providers do you currently use, and why?

Reliability (10 minutes)

Tell me about a specific time the service worked exactly as you needed it to. What happened?

Describe a time when the service failed you during an important transaction. What were the consequences for your business?

Are there particular times of day or days of the week when the service is less reliable? What do you do during those times?

Assurance (8 minutes)

How safe do you feel keeping your business capital in your mobile wallet?

What specifically makes you trust or distrust your provider?

How do you feel about the agents in Berekuso? Do you trust all of them equally?

Tangibles (6 minutes)

How easy is it to navigate the menus on your phone when sending or checking money?

Do you feel the messages and receipts you receive are clear and easy to understand?

Is there anything about the way the service looks or works on your phone that makes it harder to use?

Empathy and Responsiveness (8 minutes)

Do you feel that the companies understand the difficulties of doing business in Berekuso?

When there is a problem, how quickly is it resolved? Walk to me through the last time you needed help.

Tell me about a time you needed urgent support during a busy market day. What happened?

Loyalty and Switching (8 minutes)

Why do you continue to use your current main provider?

Have you ever stopped using a provider? What was the final experience that led to that decision?

Why do you carry more than one SIM card or use more than one mobile money wallet?

What would a provider need to do differently for you to use only them and feel confident doing so?

Closing Questions

Is there anything else about your experience with mobile money in Berekuso that you think is important for me to understand?

If you could speak directly to the CEO of your network provider, what is the one thing you would ask them to fix?

Appendix D
Thematic Coding Framework

Table D.1 summarises the coding framework applied during data analysis. The deductive phase produced 47 codes derived from the five SERVQUAL dimensions. The inductive phase produced 19 additional codes capturing themes that emerged from the data beyond the framework's original scope. The six final themes were generated through the clustering and refinement process described in Chapter 3.

Phase	Codes Generated	Examples	Final Theme
Deductive – Reliability	14 codes	network_failure_peak, ghost_transaction, signal_dead_zone, delivery_delay_peak	The Reliability Gap
Deductive – Assurance	9 codes	unresolved_loss, agent_distrust, institutional_trust_erosion, fraud_fear	Dual-Layer Assurance
Deductive – Tangibles	7 codes	English_interface_barrier, USSD_navigation_difficulty, SMS_receipt_unclear	The Literacy Tax
Deductive – Empathy	8 codes	fee_social_friction, seasonal_ignorance, literacy_ignored_in_design	Rural-Corporate Divide
Deductive – Responsiveness	9 codes	call_centre_inaccessible, airtime_cost_support, city_office_directive	Service Abandonment
Inductive	19 codes	social_cost_of_fees, SIM_juggling, gendered_exclusion, topography_barrier, E-levy_impact	Strategic Multi-homing (+ feeds into all dimensions)

Appendix E
Data Saturation Matrix

Table E.1 maps the appearance of the six major themes across the 17 interviews in sequence. Thematic saturation, the point at which no new themes emerged, was reached at participant 14. Participants 15, 16, and 17 confirmed existing themes without introducing new codes. ✓ indicates theme present; (✓) indicates partial or tangential reference.

Participant	Reliability Gap	Dual Assurance	Literacy Tax	Rural-Corp. Divide	Service Abandon.	Strategic Multi-homing
1 (A)	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓
2 (B)	✓		✓			✓
3 (G)	✓	✓		✓	✓	✓
4 (SY)	✓				✓	✓
5 (S)	✓			✓		✓
6 (L)	✓				✓	✓
7 (J)	(✓)	✓				✓
8 (PH)	✓	✓	✓			✓
9 (E1)	✓		✓	✓		✓
10 (E2)	✓	✓			✓	✓
11 (O)	✓					✓
12 (F)	✓			✓	✓	✓
13 (GO)	✓	✓			✓	✓
14 (P)	(✓)	✓	✓			✓
15 (E3)	✓		✓			✓
16 (E4)	✓			✓		✓
17 (T)	(✓)				✓	✓

Appendix F
Achievement of Research Objectives

Table F.1 maps each research objective stated in Chapter 1 to the findings that address it and the chapter section where evidence is presented.

Research Objective	Finding	Chapter Section
1. Identify service quality challenges across SERVQUAL dimensions in daily mobile money use	Reliability Gap (3 sub-themes), Dual Assurance, Literacy Tax, Rural-Corporate Divide (2 sub-themes)	Sections 4.3.1–4.3.4
2. Explore reasons for loyalty or switching behaviour	Strategic Multi-homing: rational simultaneous multi-provider hedging in response to systemic unreliability	Sections 4.4.5, 4.4 Discussion
3. Identify service improvements to rebuild loyalty	Six evidence-grounded recommendations including automated reversals, voice alerts in Twi, local-agent support	Section 4.5; Chapter 5 §5.3
4. Examine how rural context shapes quality-loyalty relationship	Infrastructure as moderating variable suppressing quality-loyalty relationship; community dynamics shaping assurance and empathy failures	Sections 4.4.1–4.4.4; Chapter 5 §5.2

All four objectives have been met. The study's central contribution, Strategic Multi-homing, emerged from the combined evidence of Objectives 1, 2, and 4, demonstrating that the findings are not isolated but interconnected through a coherent explanatory framework.

Appendix G
Synthesis: What Literature Establishes and What It Misses

Study	Method & Context	Key Finding	Gap Left
Boateng & Narteh (2016)	Quantitative SERVQUAL, urban Ghana banking	Reliability + responsiveness explain 61% of loyalty	Rural context; assumes stable infrastructure
Kankam Jr (2020)	Survey, urban Ghanaian banks	85% loyalty driven by switching costs, not satisfaction	Mobile money dynamics; rural populations
Agyei et al. (2020)	Survey, urban digital Ghana	Trust accounts for 50% of digital loyalty intentions	Rural users; SERVQUAL dimensions not decomposed

Boateng et al. (2024)	Qualitative, rural Ashanti, Ghana	Mobile money bridges banking gaps; service quality neglected	Customer loyalty; SERVQUAL not applied
Guermond (2022)	Qualitative, urban Ghana remittances	Commercial capture harms rural user welfare	Everyday transactions; rural business loyalty
Shaikh et al. (2015)	Qualitative, South Africa & Finland	Trust is primary driver of continuous use	Specific SERVQUAL dimensions not identified
Luka & Akadon (2025)	Mixed methods, rural Nigeria, Kenya, Ghana	Infrastructure barriers to adoption	Post-adoption loyalty; site-specific analysis
Baiden (2024)	Mixed methods, urban Ghana fintech	AI features drive satisfaction; rural gap wider	Rural users; qualitative depth; loyalty focus

Appendix H

Recommendation For fintech providers

Finding	Recommendation	Grounding in Evidence
Weekend network collapses (Reliability)	Invest in capacity management systems that scale infrastructure for predictable peak demand periods, particularly Saturday market hours.	16/17 participants cited peak-hour outages as primary frustration (Section 4.3.1)
Ghost transactions (Reliability)	Implement an automated USSD-based Flag and Reverse feature enabling users to halt suspected duplicate charges immediately.	Participants G and SY: funds lost to ghost transactions, unresolved over months (Section 4.3.1)
Agent trust concerns (Assurance)	Introduce visible agent certification, standardized transaction receipts, and an anonymous community reporting channel for agent misconduct.	Participant P and others: fear of agent data misuse in community context (Section 4.3.2)
English-only interface (Tangibles)	Launch Twi and Ga audio transaction confirmations and voice-menu navigation as a standard feature, not an accessibility add-on.	Participants B and PH: dependence on literate family members, loss of financial privacy (Section 4.3.3)
Inaccessible support (Responsiveness)	Establish community-level support agents in rural zones, empowered to resolve account issues without requiring users to travel to city offices.	Participant F: directed to Accra for account unlock; transport cost exceeded account balance (Section 4.3.4)
Fee social costs (Empathy)	Introduce a tiered fee structure that eliminates transaction fees for registered micro-vendors on payments below 20 Cedis.	Participant S: social cost of passing fees to customers in tight-knit community (Section 4.3.4)

Appendix I

The following table summarizes the coding output: A 20% random sample of coded excerpts was reviewed by the supervisor with no material disagreements.

Coding Phase	Codes Generated	Example Codes
Deductive (SERVQUAL)	47 codes	network_failure_peak_hours, ghost_transaction, agent_distrust, English_interface_barrier, call_centre_inaccessible
Inductive	19 codes	social_cost_of_fees, SIM_juggling_strategy, literacy_tax, gendered_exclusion, topography_as_barrier
Final Themes	6 major themes	Reliability Gap, Dual Assurance, Literacy Tax, Social Cost, Service Abandonment, Strategic Multi-homing

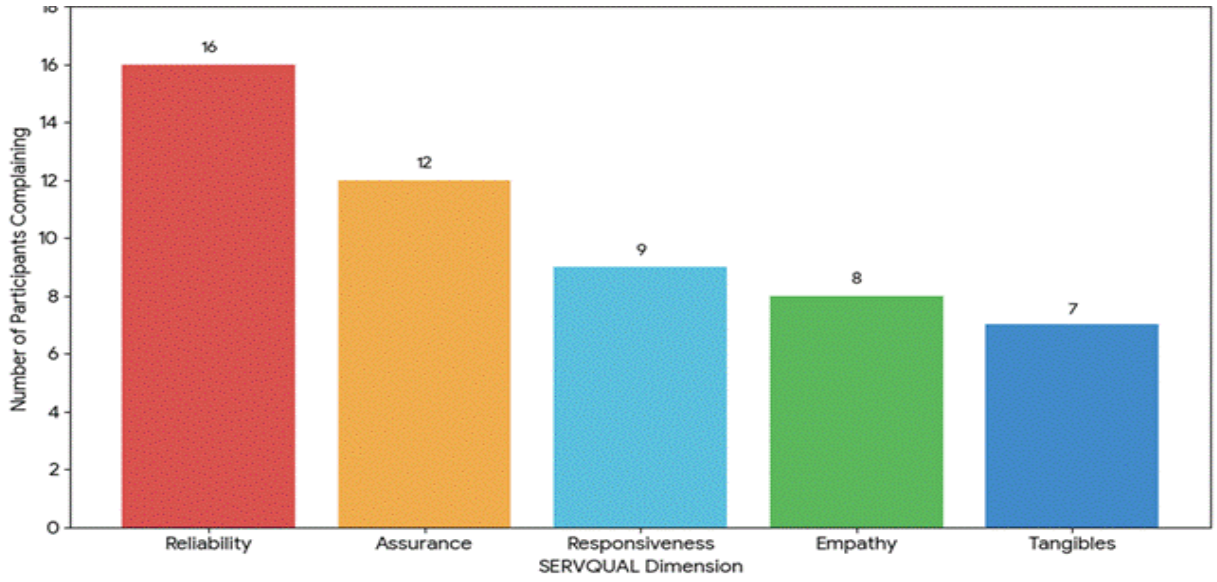
Appendix J

maps the key findings to existing scholarship and identifies the theoretical contribution each makes.

Finding	Relationship to Literature	Theoretical Contribution
Reliability failures as 'financial trauma'	Extends Boateng et al. (2024)	Reliability reframed as economic viability condition, not satisfaction predictor
Dual-layer assurance: system vs. agent trust	Extends Shaikh et al. (2015)	Trust disaggregated into institutional and interpersonal constructs; separate interventions required
The Literacy Tax	Extends Baiden (2024) and van Dijk (2020)	Interface accessibility reframed as provider design failure; gendered exclusion mechanism identified
Social cost of transaction fees	Extends Guermond (2022)	New contribution: service quality must evaluate community-level consequences
Service abandonment in support infrastructure	Confirms and extends Boateng et al. (2024)	Structural inaccessibility documented as systemic design failure producing two-tier service
Strategic Multi-homing	Challenges Kankam Jr (2020) and SERVQUAL	New concept: simultaneous multi-provider hedging; environmental infrastructure as moderating variable

Appendix K

The graph visualizing the Number of participants complaining against SERVQUAL Dimension



Appendix L

Summary of Conceptual Framework and Variable Relationships

Component	Variable Type	Definition in the Berekuso Context	Thematic Link
SERVQUAL Dimensions	Independent Variables	The core service standards (Reliability, Assurance, Tangibles, Empathy, Responsiveness) provided by Telcos.	Measures the quality of the service encountered by the business owner.
Trust & Perceived Risk	Mediating Variable	The user's confidence in the system after experiencing "ghost transactions" or agent fraud.	Acts as the "bridge" between service quality and the decision to stay.
Strategic Multi-homing	Dependent Variable (Outcome)	The survival tactic of carrying multiple SIM cards to hedge against network failure.	Represents "Involuntary Loyalty", staying because there is no single reliable choice.
Brand Advocacy	Dependent Variable (Outcome)	True loyalty where a user recommends a specific provider to others in the community.	Represents "Voluntary Loyalty" driven by high satisfaction and empathy.

Appendix M

Thematic Mapping (From Raw Quotes to Findings)

Explanation of the Analysis Process

To ensure the study remained "human-centric" while maintaining academic rigor, I followed this specific path for every interview:

1. **Transcription & Immersion:** I listened to the recordings several times to catch not just the words, but the *tone* (the frustration in Alfred's voice or the resignation in Benedicta's).
2. **Generating Codes:** I tagged phrases that repeated. For example, the phrase *"The network is down"* appeared so often it became a primary code for **Network Instability**.
3. **Thematic Clustering:** I grouped these codes under the **SERVQUAL** dimensions. This allowed me to see that "Language" wasn't just a communication issue—it was a **Tangible** failure of the service design.
4. **Saturation Check:** By the time I interviewed the 17th person, no new codes were being created. The table above represents the "saturated" categories that define the Berekuso fintech experience.

(Ctrl)

Appendix N

Connect to my research Questions

A Note on How This Connects to My Research Questions

As I walk through the findings, I've organized them to directly answer the four questions I set out to explore:

- **First**, I look at the specific service quality challenges people face, organized around the five SERVQUAL dimensions. You'll find that in Sections 4.3.1 through 4.3.5.
- **Second**, I dig into why people decide to stick with one provider or keep switching between them. That story unfolds in Section 4.4.
- **Third**, I highlight what improvements people actually want, what they would change if they could talk directly to the people running these services. That's in Section 4.5.
- **Fourth**, I explore the coping strategies people have developed to get by when things go wrong. That theme runs throughout the chapter but comes into focus most clearly in Section 4.4.5, where I talk about what I call "Strategic Multi-homing", the practice of juggling multiple SIM cards just to stay safe.

The People I Spoke With

Before diving into the findings, let me give you a sense of who shared their stories with me. I interviewed 9 women and 8 men, a fairly even split that helped me see whether men and women experienced things differently. They came from three main walks of life:

Who They Are	How Many	What Their Days Look Like
Market vendors	7	Daily transactions, handling cash and mobile payments back and forth, often working with thin margins
Student entrepreneurs	5	Running small businesses while studying, think phone repairs, small-scale retail, food sales, and comfortable with technology
Transport and service workers	5	Drivers, load carriers, people whose work keeps them moving through different parts of Berekuso throughout the day

This mix gave me a full picture of how mobile money touches different kinds of livelihoods in Berekuso. The market vendors deal with high volumes of transactions; the students bring a tech-savvy perspective but still face the same reliability issues; the transport workers experience the geography of service quality firsthand; they know exactly where the signal drops and where it comes back.

Appendix O : Part 2: Interviews Questions:

4.4.6 Summary of Discussion: Contributions to Theory

The analysis above makes several contributions to the understanding of service quality in rural fintech contexts:

Finding	Confirms/Extends/Challenges	Source
Reliability failures cause "financial trauma"	Extends: Shows reliability as economic lifeline, not just technical metric	Boateng et al. (2024)
Fear of agent data leaks	Extends: Distinguishes trust in technology vs. human intermediaries	Shaikh et al. (2015)
"Literacy Tax" excludes non-literate users	Confirms: Digital literacy as barrier to true inclusion	Baiden (2024)
Call centers as "digital walls"	Confirms: Commercial capture where profit overrides user welfare	Guermond (2022)
Social cost of transaction fees	Extends: Service quality has community-level consequences	New contribution
Strategic multi-homing as survival tactic	Challenges: Assumption that high quality leads to loyalty	SERVQUAL foundational literature